

Bernard,

What joy! We just celebrated your birthday today, our lodge full of merriment and revelry. Yet as I write, now, the world is quiet with the sounds of sleep.

The world is peaceful tonight; the stars are beautiful. Remember when I used to wake you from your slumber on the weekends in the early morn' (reluctant as you were at first, ha!)? When the sky was dark and the air was a chill, biting cold. You would wrap yourself in a blanket and follow me across the frosted grass, and we would look up at the sky together. I taught you the easy ones that I remembered, from all of the constellations your mother taught me. She always told me she couldn't wait to teach you how to read the stars. How she would make sure you could always find your way back home, and know when the seasons would change. I wanted you to see the best of her through me, even if you never had the chance to meet her. And then you went and learned the rest on your own; you would be the one waking me up in the mornings to stargaze. You remind me so much of your mother, Bernard. She would be so proud.

You grew up far too fast for this old man, but I was never once worried about your future. I had always expected you would head the family fishing business; stay in Eastbrook; find a partner and settle down. When you declined it all... well, I know we didn't get along for some time.

I know we've made up now, but I can't help but wonder what could have been if I had continued to be the supportive father I had always strived to be for you. Maybe, just maybe, we would still go out stargazing on those nights when you came home after your long trips. I could show you that I've been learning them all the while, while you were out seeing the world.

I'm putting this letter in with the rest of your things with the hope that you won't reach the bottom of your pack until you finish your week's worth of rations. This is to keep you safe.

Many moons ago, I needed to keep the business afloat to support us. Before we became

successful. Not long before you were born. Your mother and I were grasping at straws, living off of what little we had; working hard to keep ourselves alive. In a lapse of judgement, I made a deal that would turn us a profit. I was in with some bad folks. Folks who didn't take kindly to my business' rapid development... marriage... raising a child. I made sure to do what they asked, so long as they would stay away from you two. I should have cut ties sooner. Maybe they wouldn't have bothered a young man with hopes and dreams and a child to raise... but this old man... they've bled me bone dry. And they want more... more than I can give. I'm more useful dead to them than alive.

They've sent someone to finish the job, Bernard. I know because they told me. And I've made sure they will never find you. I want you nowhere near me when death knocks. This is my burden to shoulder - my greed to atone for.

But I'm not scared. I'm at peace knowing that I can protect you. You're going far away. Far away where they'll never find you. Where you can travel the world and see the sky from every angle. Where you can learn so much and continue to be the great man I know you are.

Every night, I'll be sure to look down from the heavens and find you in the sea of shining stars that walk the Forgotten Realms. You're one of them, my boy. The brightest one. You're going to do great things.

I'm so proud of you, Bernard. And I love you so very much. May we meet again among the constellations.

Love,
Dad